

DECISION-GRADE OPPORTUNITY ASSESSMENT

African SaaS Opportunity Portfolio

Feasibility, risk, commercial economics and execution recommendations across nine vertical ideas

FINAL RECOMMENDATION Focus Stoquify on an offline-capable retail-distribution operating system. Start with stock, purchasing, orders, customer credit, collections and reconciliation for one vertical in one country. Embed compliance as a moat. Do not launch nine sector products.

Prepared from a three-specialist review of market demand, unit economics, regulation, risk and distribution
14 July 2026

Executive decision

The original report's central thesis is correct: Africa's incomplete business digitization creates real vertical-software opportunities. Its main weakness was that it presented nine sectors as if they were similarly attractive. They are not. Need, market size and social importance do not automatically produce a viable SaaS business.

DECISION RULE A strong opportunity controls money, stock, customer credit, mandatory evidence or another recurring operational truth for a buyer who can pay. Need alone is not a market.

The recommended strategy

1. **Keep the existing Stoquify retail operating core** and verticalize it for inventory-intensive, multi-branch businesses.
2. **Expand upstream into distributor field sales**, customer credit and collections through one anchor distributor.
3. **Use country-specific e-invoicing**, accounting evidence and audit controls as an embedded moat.
4. **Defer separate school**, property, fleet, payroll, healthcare and agriculture products until the core motion is profitable and repeatable.

Preferred initial vertical

Building materials and hardware distribution-retail networks are the strongest default wedge. They combine meaningful stock value, customer credit, delivery, purchasing and multi-branch control without the patient-data risk of healthcare or the direct-farmer economics of agriculture. Auto parts is a credible second choice. A different vertical should win only when founder access to paying customers is materially stronger.

Why this recommendation fits the existing asset

The current workspace already shows capabilities and release controls across inventory, sales/orders, POS, purchasing, reporting, permissions, accounting and payroll assurance. Reusing that foundation reduces time-to-proof and makes a retail-to-distribution sequence more rational than restarting in an unrelated sector.

What the evidence actually says

IFC estimates that more than 600,000 formal firms and 40 million microbusinesses could benefit from digital upgrades, but fewer than one in three digitally adopting firms use technology intensively. Cost, infrastructure, skills and financing remain real barriers. This supports the opportunity while warning against assuming automatic adoption. [S1]

GSMA reports 416 million mobile-internet users in Africa in 2024, only 28% penetration, while 64% of the population lives within coverage but does not use mobile internet. Products therefore need low-bandwidth, assisted and sometimes offline operating models. [S2]

Mobile-money growth makes collections and reconciliation powerful entry points, but registered accounts should not be confused with reliable recurring card subscriptions. Billing, collections and failed-payment recovery must be localized. [S3, S17]

Five corrections to the original thesis

- Africa is a portfolio of national markets, not one software localization problem.
- Microbusiness count is not serviceable market size; many firms cannot yet sustain subscription and onboarding costs.
- Free government invoicing tools may increase compliance demand while reducing willingness to pay for a standalone invoicing product.
- The highest-need sectors can have the weakest pure-SaaS economics because field operations, regulation or hardware dominate delivery.
- Distribution is part of the product: trusted accountants, distributors, banks, PSPs and associations can matter more than online marketing.

ONE-LINE THESIS One country + one vertical + one financially measurable workflow + service-assisted onboarding.

Evaluation method and scorecard

The market score is a comparative decision tool, not a market-size forecast. Each category was scored 1-5 using the following weights: demand urgency 20%, buyer willingness to pay 20%, reachable market structure 10%, competitive whitespace 10%, implementation ease 15%, recurring-revenue quality 15%, and expansion potential 10%.

Risk is shown separately because a high-demand opportunity may still be a poor first business. Strategic fit is also separated so the recommendation reflects the existing Stoquify asset rather than evaluating every idea as a greenfield startup.

Rank	Opportunity	Score	Risk	Verdict	Decision note
1	Distributor field sales and credit	4.40	Medium	GO	Best market economics; anchor-distributor distribution.
2	Vertical retail operations	4.10	Medium-low	GO	Best fit with current Stoquify capabilities.
3	Compliance workflow	3.75	High	CONDITIONAL	Embed as moat; do not promise universal automated compliance.
4	School finance and operations	3.60	Medium-high	CONDITIONAL	Viable through school networks or payment partners.
4	Fleet and transport controls	3.60	Medium	CONDITIONAL	Software-first; partner for hardware and telematics.
6	Payroll and workforce	3.55	High	CONDITIONAL	Sticky but country-rule and liability intensive.
7	Property operations	3.45	Medium	CONDITIONAL	Target professional managers, not individual landlords.
8	Clinics and pharmacies	3.30	Very high	NARROW ONLY	Operational pharmacy wedge only; defer clinical records.
9	Agriculture	2.75	Operationally high	NO-GO DIRECT	Only B2B2C with a solvent aggregator or off-taker.

How to interpret the verdicts

- **GO:** strong enough to test immediately with paid design partners.
- **CONDITIONAL:** viable only with the stated customer, partner, regulatory or delivery conditions.
- **NARROW ONLY:** enter through a low-risk operational wedge and exclude the hardest regulated workflow.
- **NO-GO DIRECT:** the idea may work through B2B2C or institutional contracts, but not as direct self-serve SaaS.

1. Distributor field sales and credit management

Market score	4.40 / 5 - highest market score
Execution risk	Medium; rises sharply if lending or receivables ownership is added
Stoquify fit	Very high adjacency to Stoquify inventory, orders, purchasing, accounting and controls
Verdict	GO. Make this the expansion direction around the retail core.

Best customer and paid wedge

Buyer: FMCG, beverage, building-material, pharmaceutical or agricultural-input distributors with multiple branches or mobile sales representatives.

Initial product: Offline rep order capture, approved price lists, customer balances, credit limits, collection proof, returns and manager review.

Pros

- The buyer has an identifiable operating budget and can measure missed orders, bad debt, route leakage and collection delays.
- Daily use creates strong retention once receivables, route history and customer balances live in the system.
- One anchor distributor can bring many downstream retailers into the network, reducing customer-acquisition cost.

Cons

- Opening receivables, product masters and route data are usually messy and expensive to migrate.
- Offline synchronization must preserve reliable balances and proof; silent conflicts would destroy trust.
- Credit tracking can drift into regulated underwriting or lending if product boundaries are not explicit.

Feasibility conditions

- Start with one vertical and an anchor distributor with several branches or roughly 20+ field users.
- Charge implementation plus a platform and per-rep/branch fee; do not rely only on payment commissions.
- Use maker-checker approval for credit limits, discounts, returns, write-offs and price overrides.
- Do not lend from the company balance sheet during the initial phase.

Economics, proof and stop conditions

Commercial shape: 10-14 week narrow MVP. Strong bootstrap potential; venture potential appears only after repeatable distributor-network expansion.

Pilot metrics: Missed orders, disputed balances, days-to-collect, overdue receivables, route completion and supervisor reporting time.

Kill or redesign: Redesign if fewer than three distributors pay, each needs a fundamentally different workflow, field users avoid the system, or offline balances cannot remain trustworthy.

Beachhead logic: Cote d'Ivoire for a Francophone/OHADA wedge; Ghana for a controlled English-speaking pilot; Nigeria only after onboarding and support are repeatable.

2. Vertical retail inventory and payment reconciliation

Market score	4.10 / 5 - second market score
Execution risk	Medium-low if the product neither holds funds nor stores raw card data
Stoquify fit	Highest direct fit with the current Stoquify product asset
Verdict	GO, but only as a vertical operating system - never as a generic POS.

Best customer and paid wedge

Buyer: Established multi-outlet or inventory-intensive retailers, especially hardware/building materials, auto parts, specialty retail, pharmacies or mini-market groups.

Initial product: Purchasing, stock movement, daily close, cash/mobile-money reconciliation, margin visibility and exception reporting.

Pros

- Stock, cash and payment discrepancies occur daily and can be expressed in financial terms.
- Operational history makes the system sticky and supports expansion into supplier ordering, accounting and compliance evidence.
- The current repository already contains inventory, sales/orders, permissions, reporting, POS, purchasing and assurance foundations.

Cons

- Generic POS is crowded, price-sensitive and vulnerable to free or low-cost government and local tools.
- Micro-merchants often have low recurring revenue and high support needs.
- Inventory cleanup, barcodes, units, opening balances, hardware and staff training can hide a services loss.

Feasibility conditions

- Choose one retail vertical in one city and target firms with staff, meaningful stock value and a known control problem.
- Charge separately for migration, configuration and training; avoid free onboarding.
- Make offline sales idempotent and conflict-safe, with append-only stock movements and explicit reconciliation queues.

- Integrate one licensed payment provider first and settle directly to the merchant.

Economics, proof and stop conditions

Commercial shape: 12-16 week vertical MVP using the existing foundation. Excellent bootstrap path; venture-scale only if it becomes a retail-distribution network or payment-control platform.

Pilot metrics: Reconciliation time, unresolved variances, shrinkage, stock adjustments, stockouts, gross-margin accuracy and time to daily close.

Kill or redesign: Redesign if customers value receipt printing but not controls, migration cannot be covered by setup fees, on-site support remains frequent, or owners refuse to pay after a full monthly control report.

Beachhead logic: Use the founder's strongest customer-access market first. For regulatory pull, Kenya and Rwanda have broad electronic-invoicing requirements; Ghana is rolling out E-VAT. For Francophone advantage, test Cote d'Ivoire or the founder's existing OHADA network.

3. Compliance workflow for accountants and regulated SMEs

Market score	3.75 / 5 - attractive but country-bound
Execution risk	High professional, tax and evidence liability
Stoquify fit	High as an embedded Stoquify moat; medium as a standalone product
Verdict	CONDITIONAL GO. Build workflow and evidence, not autonomous legal conclusions.

Best customer and paid wedge

Buyer: Accounting firms, payroll bureaus, regulated SMEs and multi-entity groups with repeated deadlines and evidence obligations.

Initial product: Deadline tracking, evidence requests, review, approval, immutable proof packs and country-specific e-invoicing connectors.

Pros

- Mandatory deadlines, penalties and denied deductions create urgency and retention.
- One accounting firm can aggregate dozens of end customers, improving distribution economics.
- Audit history, evidence and country adapters deepen the operational product's defensibility.

Cons

- Tax and filing rules remain national even where OHADA harmonizes accounting.
- Revenue authorities may provide free invoicing or filing tools, weakening standalone pricing.
- Incorrect outputs can create financial, professional and reputational liability.

Feasibility conditions

- Pick one country and one recurring obligation; maintain effective-dated, expert-reviewed rule packs.
- Separate the accounting kernel from tax adapters and preserve source evidence for every claim.
- Require accountant review for filings; do not market AI output as tax, legal or audit certification.
- Sell through accountants, professional bodies and implementation partners.

Economics, proof and stop conditions

Commercial shape: 8-12 week MVP for one workflow. Strong bootstrap model if setup is paid and one firm brings multiple managed entities.

Pilot metrics: Clients handled per accountant, missing-document follow-ups, review hours, missed deadlines and evidence-pack completion time.

Kill or redesign: Stop if accountants will not place real clients into a paid pilot, rule maintenance is uneconomic, or the product saves less time than email, spreadsheets and shared folders.

Beachhead logic: Cote d'Ivoire or Senegal for an OHADA-informed product with local tax expertise; Kenya, Rwanda and Ghana offer visible e-invoicing integration opportunities.

4. School fee collection and administration

Market score	3.60 / 5 - viable niche
Execution risk	Medium-high due child data, payment disputes and seasonal budgets
Stoquify fit	Low-medium relative to the existing retail-distribution asset
Verdict	CONDITIONAL. Pursue only through a school network or payment partner.

Best customer and paid wedge

Buyer: Private or faith-based schools with roughly 300+ pupils, or multi-school groups with persistent fee and reconciliation problems.

Initial product: Fee billing, installments, unique payment references, arrears, receipts, reconciliation and guardian communication.

Pros

- Fee collection is central to school cash flow and has repeatable term cycles.
- Mobile-money references and reminders can improve visibility and reduce manual reconciliation.
- An association, church or school group can aggregate many customers.

Cons

- Budgets are constrained and revenue is seasonal; parent affordability is not a software problem.
- Student imports, sibling discounts, calendars and parent support create substantial onboarding work.
- Child and guardian data require tighter access, minimization and messaging controls.

Feasibility conditions

- Minimize child data, separate guardian permissions and avoid public student identifiers.
- Support offline receipt capture and SMS/USSD fallbacks where smartphones are not universal.
- Price annually or per term, plus implementation; route payments through a licensed provider.

Economics, proof and stop conditions

Commercial shape: 8-12 week fee-management MVP. Better bootstrapped than venture-backed unless network distribution is proven.

Pilot metrics: Collection rate, days-to-collect, arrears, reconciliation hours and incorrect payment allocations.

Kill or redesign: Stop if sales remain one-school-at-a-time, parent support overwhelms margins, or the product creates more work for administrators.

Beachhead logic: Kenya has mature mobile payments and broad eTIMS scope including schools; Ghana, Uganda and Nigeria require a concentrated private-school channel.

5. Fleet, dispatch and fuel controls

Market score	3.60 / 5 - attractive with the right partner
Execution risk	Medium; becomes capital-intensive when hardware is owned
Stoquify fit	Medium adjacency to distributor operations
Verdict	CONDITIONAL. Software first; partner for telematics and installation.

Best customer and paid wedge

Buyer: Distributors, delivery fleets, construction firms, bus operators and service businesses with roughly 20-200 vehicles.

Initial product: Dispatch, trip proof, fuel variance, maintenance, driver cash and route profitability.

Pros

- Fuel leakage, downtime and unauthorized trips create measurable ROI.
- Daily operational history supports high retention.
- Insurers, fuel-card providers, lessors and telematics installers can become channels.

Cons

- GPS devices, phones, mapping and installation support can overwhelm SaaS margins.
- Driver monitoring creates privacy, trust and labor-relations concerns.
- False fraud alerts and inaccurate GPS data quickly damage credibility.

Feasibility conditions

- Integrate existing hardware rather than manufacturing or financing devices.
- Give drivers transparent monitoring policies and restrict live-location access.
- Begin with fuel, maintenance and proof-of-delivery controls before predictive claims.

Economics, proof and stop conditions

Commercial shape: 8-12 week software-only MVP. Bootstrap viable with partner-owned hardware; proprietary telematics requires more capital.

Pilot metrics: Fuel variance, downtime, unauthorized trips, vehicle utilization and on-time delivery.

Kill or redesign: Stop if hardware failures dominate support, partner integrations are unreliable or customers expect guaranteed fraud detection.

Beachhead logic: Kenya and East African trade corridors, Ghana, then Nigeria after operational reliability is proven.

6. Payroll and workforce administration

Market score	3.55 / 5 - sticky but assurance-heavy
Execution risk	High due salary privacy, statutory correctness and deadline concentration
Stoquify fit	Medium-high technically, but a separate go-to-market and country-maintenance commitment
Verdict	CONDITIONAL. Sequence after audit, approval and country-pack governance mature.

Best customer and paid wedge

Buyer: Formal employers with tens to hundreds of employees, payroll bureaus and accounting firms.

Initial product: Country-specific payroll preparation, effective-dated statutory deductions, approvals, payment files and accounting reconciliation.

Pros

- Payroll is non-discretionary, monthly and extremely sticky when trusted.
- Errors have visible financial and employee consequences, supporting willingness to pay.
- Accountants, HR consultants, banks and employer associations can distribute the product.

Cons

- Country rules, allowances, pensions and social-security integrations create ongoing expert costs.
- Support concentrates around hard payroll deadlines and a single error can destroy trust.
- The category is crowded by global, pan-African and country-specific providers.

Feasibility conditions

- Launch one country pack and one workforce segment; never promise all-African payroll initially.
- Use four-eyes approval, pre-run variance checks, encrypted salary data and versioned rules.
- Separate calculation from money custody and payment initiation until regulated partnerships exist.

Economics, proof and stop conditions

Commercial shape: 12-18 week uncomplicated salaried-payroll MVP. Bootstrap viable for one country; venture case requires repeatable country-pack architecture.

Pilot metrics: Payroll preparation hours, correction rate, support minutes per employee, on-time completion and reconciliation exceptions.

Kill or redesign: Stop expansion if statutory maintenance requires permanent bespoke work or recurring support prevents attractive gross profit.

Beachhead logic: Ghana or Kenya for an initial English pack; Cote d'Ivoire where genuine Francophone payroll expertise and customer access exist.

7. Property rent collection and maintenance

Market score	3.45 / 5 - reasonable niche
Execution risk	Medium due tenant data, local tenancy law and payment boundaries
Stoquify fit	Low-medium relative to the current product
Verdict	CONDITIONAL. Target professional managers, never fragmented individual landlords first.

Best customer and paid wedge

Buyer: Property managers, student-housing operators, commercial landlords and owners with 50-100+ units.

Initial product: Lease and opening-balance import, unique payment references, rent reconciliation, arrears, maintenance and owner statements.

Pros

- Rent and payment history are recurring workflows with natural retention.
- Professional managers can quantify arrears, reconciliation work and statement preparation.

- Banks, estate agents, developers and licensed payment providers can provide channels.

Cons

- Individual landlords are fragmented, informal and often too price-sensitive for efficient acquisition.
- Tenant affordability and disputes cannot be solved by workflow software alone.
- Payment custody or escrow would trigger a substantially different regulatory model.

Feasibility conditions

- Let a licensed provider settle directly to the owner; reconcile references without holding rent.
- Preserve allocation evidence and provide clear dispute workflows.
- Avoid listings and marketplaces until the operating system has retention.

Economics, proof and stop conditions

Commercial shape: 8-12 week MVP. Good bootstrapped niche with portfolio-based pricing and paid setup.

Pilot metrics: Collection rate, arrears, unallocated payments, occupancy visibility and owner-statement preparation time.

Kill or redesign: Stop if the majority of leads are tiny landlords, managers bypass the platform or tenant support exceeds subscription margin.

Beachhead logic: Kenya and Rwanda have visible electronic-invoicing relevance for rental-income taxpayers; validate professional-manager concentration first.

8. Clinic operations and medical-stock management

Market score	3.30 / 5 - high need, difficult first business
Execution risk	Very high due sensitive health data, uptime and clinical safety
Stoquify fit	Low unless limited to pharmacy inventory and operational billing
Verdict	NARROW ENTRY ONLY. Defer full clinical records and decision support.

Best customer and paid wedge

Buyer: Private clinic groups, diagnostic centers, dental practices and pharmacy networks with professional administration.

Initial product: Non-clinical scheduling, billing, batch/expiry stock, procurement and cash/insurance reconciliation.

Pros

- Medicine stockouts, expiry and revenue leakage are frequent and financially important.

- Embedded operational history can produce high retention.
- Provider groups, insurers and pharmacy networks can aggregate customers.

Cons

- Patient identity, confidentiality, interoperability and migration create severe implementation obligations.
- Downtime can interrupt care and a breach can cause lasting harm.
- WHO reports fragmented, paper-heavy health information systems and weak interoperability across the region.

Feasibility conditions

- Begin outside clinical decision-making and prohibit autonomous clinical advice.
- Use strong tenant isolation, break-glass logs, backups, disaster recovery and privacy impact assessment.
- Partner with provider networks and employ health-governance expertise before handling patient records.

Economics, proof and stop conditions

Commercial shape: 16-24 week narrow outpatient product; likely needs patient capital or a strategic partner, not a lean first bootstrap product.

Pilot metrics: Medicine expiry, stockouts, billing leakage, claim-document completeness, uptime and support burden.

Kill or redesign: Defer if no anchor network exists, security maturity is insufficient, or clinicians experience slower workflows.

Beachhead logic: Ghana or Kenya through a pharmacy/provider network; Nigeria only with a strong anchor institution.

9. Agricultural aggregation and traceability

Market score	2.75 / 5 - lowest direct-SaaS score
Execution risk	Operationally high; payment, credit and insurance additions increase regulation
Stoquify fit	Low as a new standalone product; possible later through distributor/off-taker adjacency
Verdict	NO-GO as farmer-paid SaaS. Consider only B2B2C with a solvent institutional payer.

Best customer and paid wedge

Buyer: Cooperatives, processors, exporters, off-takers, input programs, insurers, banks, governments or NGOs - not individual farmers.

Initial product: Farmer registry, delivery/weighing proof, traceability, procurement, quality evidence and provider-routed payments for one value chain.

Pros

- The need is enormous and digital records can support traceability, finance and market access.
- A committed aggregator can make an otherwise fragmented market reachable.
- Institutional contracts can be substantial when the software controls transactions and evidence.

Cons

- Direct farmer willingness and ability to pay are weak; demand is seasonal and geographically dispersed.
- Field identity, shared devices, coverage, data quality and agent training make rollout expensive.
- Grant-funded free alternatives and donor cycles distort recurring SaaS economics.

Feasibility conditions

- Secure a paying off-taker or cooperative before development.
- Support offline capture, farmer-visible statements and signed delivery evidence.
- Route payments through regulated providers; avoid advice-only products and balance-sheet lending.

Economics, proof and stop conditions

Commercial shape: 12-18 week technical MVP, but field pilots are much longer. Better suited to grants, strategic capital or blended finance.

Pilot metrics: Verified deliveries, payment exceptions, farmer identity match rate, field-support cost and repeat use across seasons.

Kill or redesign: Do not launch without a solvent payer, a controlled value chain and a credible field-distribution partner.

Beachhead logic: Ghana with an aggregator; Rwanda, Malawi or Zimbabwe through organized cooperatives or programs. Institutional access matters more than national TAM.

Country and beachhead decision

Country selection should be driven first by customer access and second by abstract market attractiveness. A founder who can obtain five paying customers in Cameroon has a better starting point than a theoretically larger market with no trusted channel.

Market	Best use	Advantages	Constraints	Decision
Cote d'Ivoire	Retail/distribution and OHADA-informed accounting	Francophone regional position; natural compliance differentiation	National tax adapter and local expert support still required	Primary if Francophone access is strong
Ghana	Controlled English retail/distribution pilot	Manageable market; visible payments and E-VAT direction	Integration and support still local	Strong alternative beachhead
Kenya	Retail compliance, schools, fleet	Mature mobile money; broad eTIMS requirement	Higher competition and customer expectations	Enter with a sharp vertical
Rwanda	Governed pilot and EBM integration	Clear EBM and privacy obligations; compact market	Small validation market	Good proof market, not final scale thesis
Cameroon	Founder-access OHADA pilot	Local relationships can outweigh market abstractions	Payment, tax and support integrations must be validated	Use if founder access is strongest
Nigeria	Later scale market	Large upside and enterprise e-invoicing demand	High fragmentation, support and compliance cost	Enter after repeatability elsewhere

Non-negotiable country gate

Before launch, document the local tax/invoicing interface, PSP/payment boundaries, data-protection obligations, record-retention rules, labor implications for tracked employees, customer-contract requirements and the named professional adviser responsible for regulated interpretations.

Recommended product definition

POSITIONING The financial-control operating system for inventory-intensive retailers and distributors in one African market - not a generic ERP, not a marketplace, and not a financial institution.

Ideal customer profile

- One distributor or established retailer with multiple branches, warehouses, sales reps or delivery activity.
- Meaningful inventory value and recurring losses from stockouts, shrinkage, pricing errors, credit or reconciliation.
- An owner, finance lead or operations manager who can approve a paid pilot and provide baseline data.
- Enough operational discipline to maintain product, customer, unit and opening-balance data.

Initial end-to-end workflow

5. Import and approve products, units, customers, opening stock and opening receivables.
6. Capture branch or field orders offline against approved price lists and credit limits.
7. Reserve or issue stock, record delivery/return proof and update customer balances.
8. Record collections through cash, bank or licensed mobile-money provider references.
9. Reconcile daily sales, stock, cash and digital payments with explicit exception queues.
10. Produce manager dashboards, audit history and tax/accounting-ready evidence.

Explicit exclusions for the first release

- No balance-sheet lending, automated credit decisions or purchased receivables.
- No customer-fund custody, escrow or raw card-data storage.
- No autonomous tax filing, audit opinion or legal-compliance guarantee.
- No proprietary hardware manufacturing or financing.
- No multi-country launch before one country has repeatable onboarding and support economics.

Business model and unit economics

Recommended commercial structure

- **Paid implementation:** migration, configuration, opening balances, training and travel.
- **Recurring platform fee:** core organization, controls, reporting and support.
- **Usage expansion:** outlets, warehouses, field users, routes or managed entities.
- **Premium modules:** reconciliation, distributor credit controls, country compliance packs and advanced evidence exports.
- **Partner fees only** where licensed providers own payment settlement or financial products.

Contribution model

GROSS PROFIT PER CUSTOMER Recurring revenue - cloud, messaging and API cost - payment fees not passed through - recurring support labor - ongoing integration and compliance maintenance.

CUSTOMER ACQUISITION COST Sales and marketing expense + founder/sales time + travel + demonstrations + free pilots + unrecovered onboarding labor.

PAYBACK Customer acquisition cost divided by monthly gross profit after recurring support.

Economic quality gates

- Setup fees recover most customer-specific implementation effort.
- Recurring support falls after the first two billing periods.
- The core money/stock workflow is used weekly or daily.
- Expansion comes from more outlets, users, routes or modules - not bespoke reports.
- Founder intervention is not required for every close, reconciliation or customer decision.

Ninety-day paid validation program

Days 1-30: evidence and commitment

- Interview 15 distributors and 15 multi-branch retailers in one vertical and one city.
- Shadow at least five order/collection routes and five store-closing or reconciliation sessions.
- Collect anonymized product masters, order books, stock adjustments, customer ledgers and reconciliation reports.
- Secure three paid distributor pilots or five paid retail pilots before broad product work.

Days 31-60: concierge proof

- Run order capture, balances, collection proof and manager review using the smallest reliable product slice.
- Charge setup and pilot fees; record every hour of migration, training, support and travel.
- Establish baseline loss, delay and labor metrics before claiming improvement.

Days 61-90: repeatability test

- Stabilize offline synchronization, audit history, reconciliation and exception workflows.
- Onboard the next similar customer using a documented checklist rather than founder improvisation.
- Produce a quantified case study only after a complete operating cycle.

PASS At least three customers pay, use the core workflow in production, show a measurable operational result, and can be onboarded without reinventing the product.

FAIL OR REDESIGN Customers praise visibility but cannot quantify value; migration exceeds recoverable setup fees; field adoption collapses; support stays bespoke; or offline balances and reconciliation cannot be trusted.

Twelve-month execution roadmap

Period	Goal	Exit evidence
Months 1-2	Select	Choose one country, vertical and buyer; complete 30 interviews; secure paid-pilot commitments.
Months 3-4	Prove	Run a concierge workflow, charge setup, record baseline metrics and reject one-off features.
Months 5-6	Productize	Harden the repeated workflow, roles, audit trail, low-bandwidth/offline behavior and one integration.
Months 7-9	Repeat	Reach 10-20 paying customers in the same segment; test one channel; standardize onboarding.
Months 10-12	Decide	Choose bootstrap or funding based on retention, contribution margin, partner referrals and expansion.

Funding decision

Bootstrap while one country can produce paid onboarding, healthy contribution margins, manageable support and partner referrals. Consider venture funding only when acquisition works beyond the founder, retention and expansion are strong, country/integration architecture is reusable, and capital will accelerate a proven engine rather than finance unresolved product-market fit.

Risk controls required before scaling

Control area	Minimum safeguard
Tenant and access	Per-tenant isolation, least privilege, strong administrator controls and periodic entitlement review.
Money-affecting actions	Maker-checker approval for credit, discounts, returns, write-offs, stock adjustments and payment exceptions.
Audit evidence	Immutable history for stock, sales, payroll, payments, filings and configuration changes.
Offline operation	Encrypted cache, device lock, remote revocation, idempotent sync and visible conflict/reconciliation queues.
Payments	Licensed PSP integration, direct settlement, no raw card storage, no customer-fund custody or escrow.
Privacy	Data-processing agreements, retention schedules, breach response, cross-border transfer mapping and data minimization.
Resilience	Restore-tested backups, degraded-mode procedures, monitoring and explicit source-unavailable states.
AI boundaries	No autonomous decisions for credit, payroll, tax, health, employee discipline or professional certification.

REGULATORY BOUNDARY Operational SaaS is materially safer than becoming a payment institution, lender, escrow provider, tax filer or clinical decision system. Cross those boundaries only deliberately, with licensed partners and country-specific advice.

Final recommendation

Proceed with a focused retail-distribution strategy. The market-only ranking favors distributor field sales and credit management, while the existing Stoquify asset strongly favors retail operations. The best combined decision is therefore a retail-distribution operating system rather than choosing one side and discarding the other.

Recommended sequence

11. Prove vertical retail controls with five paid businesses in one city and one inventory-intensive sector.
12. Secure one anchor distributor and extend into rep orders, customer credit, collections and returns.
13. Add payment reconciliation and country-specific e-invoicing/evidence as the defensive layer.
14. Use the distributor relationship to reach downstream merchants economically.
15. Expand countries only after onboarding, support and country-pack governance are repeatable.

What not to do

- Do not present Stoquify as an all-in-one platform for every African SME.
- Do not launch separate school, clinic, agriculture and property products in parallel.
- Do not subsidize onboarding indefinitely or mistake services losses for SaaS growth.
- Do not enter lending, fund custody, autonomous filing or clinical advice to make the pitch look larger.

BOTTOM LINE The opportunity is attractive, but focus is the advantage. Build the system that protects stock, credit, collections and evidence for a buyer who already loses money without it.

Sources and evidence notes

Sources are current to 14 July 2026 unless an earlier publication date is shown. Regulatory pages support market-selection hypotheses, not legal sign-off. Rules must be revalidated with local advisers before launch.

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Method and limitations

This assessment combines current authoritative sources, an independent market-attractiveness review, a founder/CFO commercial review, a risk/regulatory/distribution review, and inspection of the current Stoquify workspace. Scores express comparative judgment rather than audited market size, guaranteed pricing or legal advice. Every recommendation remains subject to paid pilot evidence.